A . . . My Name is Alice

Conceived by Joan Micklin Silver and Julianne Boyd

Suggested Roles: *ACTRESS 1: Split lines for POETESS, MS. THOMAS, WORKMAN*
ACTRESS 2: Split lines for POETESS, MRS. JOHNSON, WOMAN

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

POETESS: (Pg 19) A poem. From my collection, *For Women Only*. *(she recites, dramatically)*

I am a woman
A crippled bird.
The ledge is cold,
My wings are clipped.
He did it.
He did it.
I was his pretty Polly.
Pity Polly.
Pity Pretty Polly,
Doesn't want a cracker.
I am a woman.
A crippled bird.
F—flap
F—flap
F—flap

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *With a wry sense of humor, these sketches from A . . . My Name is Alice address the challenges of being a woman.*
ACTRESS 2: *From beatnik poetry (finger snaps),*
ACTRESS 1: *To being a power-mom in the cut-throat professional world,*
ACTRESS 2: *To merely taking a stroll down the street alone –*
ACTRESS 1: *Women must be prepared to handle it all*
ACTRESS 2: *And smile while we're doing it!*
ACTRESS 1: *A . . . My Name is Alice*
ACTRESS 2: *Conceived by Joan Micklin Silver and Julianne Boyd*

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Welcome to Kindergarten, Mrs. Johnson (Pg 21-24)

MS. THOMAS: Welcome to kindergarten, Mrs. Johnson.

MRS. JOHNSON: How do you do? It's a pleasure meeting you. Janie has told me so much about you.

MS. THOMAS: It's a shame you couldn't make it to last week's meeting like the other mothers.

MRS. JOHNSON: I'm sorry. I was speaking at a conference in Zurich.

MS. THOMAS: Well, come along. *(crosses back to her desk)* I've been observing Janie very closely. She's a very bright girl, Mrs. Johnson. She works beyond potential—a model for her peers, exploring at a level that is way beyond her years. And I'm sorry, but it's getting on my nerves.

MRS. JOHNSON: I'm sorry.

MS. THOMAS: Don't fidget, Mrs. Johnson. *(beat)* She's a difficult girl, Mrs. Johnson. She helps the other children—Lord knows where it will lead. And I've learned that when my back is turned, she's teaching them to read. I'm to say the least dismayed—what does she think this is, third grade? She's independent, she's assertive, she's always self-assured. Now I don't know where she's getting that, but it is not to be ignored—and it generally starts at the home. Did you know that Janie is the only child in class with an even reasonable self-image. Now who's responsible for ***that***?

MRS. JOHNSON: *(a bit thrown)* I am.

MS. THOMAS: I'm sorry?

MRS. JOHNSON: *(louder)* I am.

MS. THOMAS: I am ***what***?

MRS. JOHNSON: I am, Ms. Thomas.

MS. THOMAS: Good. Well, how do you expect her to be intimidated by simple authority?

MRS. JOHNSON: Well, I . . .

MS. THOMAS: Now, I'm not saying you're a bad mother, even though you missed our pageant And the Halloween parade. No, no one's saying you're a bad mother, but your cookies at the bake sale, well, they clearly weren't homemade.

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MRS. JOHNSON: *(abashed)* They were Pepperidge Farm Mint Milanos!

MS. THOMAS: The other mothers baked.

MRS. JOHNSON: I know, but. . . but I hate baking.

MS. THOMAS: Janie was humiliated!

MRS. JOHNSON: She never said a thing to me!

MS. THOMAS: Well, you're a busy little bee, Mrs. Johnson. Zipping off to Zurich. I hear next week it's Rome. Is there really any wonder things are suffering at home? *(Mrs. Johnson starts to protest)* Oh, there's no need to object. It's all here in Janie's artwork—you can see that I'm correct. *(She produces a large pig made out of a Clorox bottle and decorated with hearts. She shows it to Mrs. Johnson)*

MRS. JOHNSON: It's a pig! Made out of a Clorox bottle!

MS. THOMAS: Oh, come on, Mrs. Johnson. There are domestic problems written all over this pig. I know what I'm talking about. I've taken psychology courses.

MRS. JOHNSON: But . . .

MS. THOMAS: If you have something to say, you raise your hand! Now, no one wants to be a -- *(she waits for Mrs. Johnson to respond)*

MRS. JOHNSON: Bad mother.

MS. THOMAS: And I think we can do better if we just make up our minds, 'cause we all know what happens to a— *(she again waits for Mrs. Johnson to respond)*

MRS. JOHNSON: Bad mother!

MS. THOMAS: And there's every indication that this suits your situation. Here's my evaluation—take it home and have it signed!

MRS. JOHNSON: *(fighting back tears)* Uh-huh.

MS. THOMAS: Did you know we have these parent-teacher conferences every Monday at four o'clock.

MRS. JOHNSON: *(shaking head)* Uh-uh.

MS. THOMAS: Well, I hope I'll be seeing you again very soon.

MRS. JOHNSON: Ye-yes, Ms. Thomas.

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MS. THOMAS: That'll be all . . . *(Mrs. Johnson flees for the door)* No running in the halls!

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POETESS: *(she continues the 2nd stanza of her poem, dramatically)*

I am a woman.
A neglected plant.
Hanging by the window
Waiting to be watered.
He did it.
He did it.
I was his philodendron
Calling out,
"Won't somebody talk
to me?"
I am a woman.
A neglected plant.
D—droop
D—droop
D—droop

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Hot Lunch (Pg 44-45)

(A workman leans on a bit of construction debris, he's on lunch break and is ogling imaginary girls that walk by)

WORKMAN: Wowee . . . beautiful, baby, beautiful . . . Hey, don't ignore me, honey; you're not that pretty . . . *(a woman enters and crosses past him)* Wowie, look at them gazoombas! I'd like to show you a taste of heaven, honey bunny.

WOMAN: *(very polite)* Excuse me, would you repeat what you just said to me?

WORKMAN: *(startled)* Huh? Oh sure. I said I'd like to show you a taste of heaven, honey bunny.

WOMAN: What else? You said something before that I couldn't quite make out.

WORKMAN: *(getting annoyed)* I don't know. I said you got a great pair of legs or something. I forget.

WOMAN: *(matter of fact)* No, no, I don't think you said legs . . . It was something more like daroombas?

WORKMAN: Hey, lady, walk on by, will ya? I'm eating my lunch.

WOMAN: Yes, and I'm very sorry to disturb you, but try to remember what you said. It's very important to me . . . Now, it sounded like . . .

WORKMAN: *(very softly)* Gazoombas.

WOMAN: Sorry, I didn't get that.

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WORKMAN: Gazoombas! Now will you please leave me alone? I'm on my lunch break.

WOMAN: I know, I know, I'm infringing on your time and I apologize for it, but what are gazoombas?

WORKMAN: Aw, just a word. A made-up word. No big deal. Look, I'm sorry, okay? I said gazoombas, so what? Since when was it a crime to give a compliment?

WOMAN: Yes, yes, I understand the motivation. It's just the word, ***gazoombas***. I'd never heard it before. What exactly does gazoombas refer to?

WORKMAN: *(embarrassed)* You know. *(indicates up)* Up there. *(She looks up)* Your chest, lady.

WOMAN: *(relieved)* Oh, thank goodness. I kind of thought that's what you meant, but I wasn't quite sure.

WORKMAN: Well, that's what I meant, okay? No offense. *(He begins to pack up)*

WOMAN: Of course not . . . so, you like my gazoombas?

WORKMAN: Hey, cool it, will you? I work here!

WOMAN: Sorry, I just wanted to know if you really appreciated my mammaries.

WORKMAN: Lady, would you excuse me? I gotta get back on the job. *(he tries to go past her and she stops him)*

WOMAN: Of course, how stupid of me. But before you go, I'd like you to see my gazoombas. *(with her back to the audience . . .)*

WORKMAN: Lady, lady, cover yourself! What are you doing?

WOMAN: I thought if I showed you my gazoombas, you'd show me your wogabongo.

WORKMAN: My what?

WOMAN: You know . . . wogabongo!!!

WORKMAN: You're wacko lady!

WOMAN: Why am I a wacko? You like my gazoombas, I like your wogabongo. I just want that taste of heaven you promised me. Why, with my gazoombas and your wogabongo, we could make great shtahpoonko.

WORKMAN: *(calling to an unseen coworker)* Hey, Joe! Help! Help! Call the cops! I got a nut-case down here! Help!

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WOMAN: *(She dusts off her hands, thoroughly pleased with herself)*

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POETESS: **(Pg 46)** *(she finishes her poem, dramatically)*

I am a woman.
A dying swan.
Dancing, dancing, dancing.
My toe shoes torn.
My tutu, too.
He did it.
He did it.
(And he knows who he is.)
That weekend he took her skiing in Aspen—
That's when he did it.
A love bullet
Straight through my feathered gazoombas.
I am a woman.
A dying swan.
Ach-ch
Ach-ch
Ach-ch

SOURCE INFORMATION

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